

imagine people arguing down there, not to mention fighting. It looks so peaceful... so calm down on earth. From space, there are no borders that you can see. We are lucky to live on such a planet and we should not take it for granted. After my space experience, I am a lot more tolerant of people and opinions, of everything."

Television records show her flying around in iss like Superwoman, her short hair billowing Medusa-like, while proudly taking viewers on a guided tour around her space home. She takes pains to explain that iss was not some kind of jail in space but as big as a 747 jet that housed just three astronauts. Not to mention the awesome view from the many portholes the spacecraft had.

Iss is an outstanding example of how nations can collaborate in space. Led by the US, the space station draws upon the scientific and technological resources of 16 nations. Williams says her defining moment came when the international crew was being changed and she found herself the most experienced on board. She says: "It was like 'wow we represent the earth'. All of a sudden, I felt responsible."

Her weekly mission blogs are laced with humour and reveal just how well she had adapted to floating around in space for six-and-a-half months. She says: "You forget that you are in something different and it all becomes very natural. It dawned on me somewhere after the four-month mark, when I got up and looked at our lab, and thought I could not imagine walking from here to there, I did not even know how it would be like. It is pretty incredible how your body can adapt to that situation. You get very efficient at flying around and you learn to control your speed."

Williams is not the first person of Indian origin to ride into space. There was Kalpana Chawla, the Haryana wonder girl, who tragically died while returning from her second space flight in 2003 when the space shuttle Columbia blew up. Earlier there was Rakesh Sharma, India's first cosmonaut, who hitched a ride on a

Russian Salyut 7 spacecraft in 1984 and orbited the earth for eight days. Not to mention the more than 460 men and women who have journeyed into space after Yuri Gagarin made the historic flight in 1961.

Unlike Chawla, who did her schooling in India before migrating to the US, Williams was born in Ohio where her father worked as a neuroanatomist. Her mother, Bonnie, is Slovenian. Yet there is much of her that remains Indian including the food she eats and the gods she prays to.

Williams took with her into space an idol of Lord Ganesha and a copy of



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the Bhagavad Gita for company. Lest she be seen as partial to her father's origins, she adds quickly that she also took copies of the *Odyssey* and *Iliad* to read.

She had never read the Gita with any depth before her space journey though her father had narrated to her the epics—the Ramayan and the Mahabharat—when she was young. She says: "This may sound a bit corny, but it sort of grounds you. In a little spacecraft zipping around the earth, you are doing a lot of things, sometimes it feels like work...may be you are taking for granted where you are, what you are doing...things like Ganesha, the Gita bring you back

home. It is nice to read about Arjuna's trials and tribulations and it puts your life in perspective."

Williams brings out the child in you—the longing to know how it feels to break free of gravity. It's an elementary question but she answers patiently, "After the blast-off you have eight-and-a-half minutes of a real bumpy ride in the shuttle. Then, all of a sudden, it goes very quiet as the main engine shuts off. At that point of time, you can undo your seatbelt. You can feel you are just starting to float up a little bit; if you have a pencil in your hand it floats out of your hand. Just as you get up, you sort of feel out of control because you are floating out of your seat. I remember we were all laughing and screaming with joy."

Then there are, what astronauts call, 1G moments when the mind finds it difficult to erase experiences on the earth. On her first space walk Williams had one such moment when she climbed to the top of the space station which is pretty high. She recalls: "I could not get over the feeling that I might fall. I had to stop myself and say, up here you

don't fall, you just float right next to it." Another time she tried eating out a bag of nuts as she would do back home—emptying the contents into her mouth. But found that the nuts don't fall out as they do on earth!

Eating food was an issue, especially the Indian stuff that she liked. She says: "Up there while eating food, you have to have one thing and then the next. You can't put it up on a plate and mix it up because it starts flying all over the place. So it was a problem eating Indian food. I am used to spicy food but some of my Russian colleagues got a little bit red in the face when they ate *shahi paneer*."

At 42, Williams is still raring to go back into space apart from sharing her experiences with those planning to go up. She says: "If I have the opportunity, I would like to go to the moon. I have this feeling though that I will be too old to go to Mars." She thinks India should send a 'manned' mission to space. Maybe we should woo her back and take her help in doing just that. ■